
Translation Practices Explained

Translation Practices Explained is a series of coursebooks designed to help self-learners and teachers of translation. Each volume focuses on a specific aspect of professional translation practice, in many cases corresponding to actual courses available in translator-training institutions. Special volumes are devoted to well consolidated professional areas, such as legal translation or European Union texts; to areas where labour-market demands are currently undergoing considerable growth, such as screen translation in its different forms; and to specific aspects of professional practices on which little teaching and learning material is available, the case of editing and revising, or electronic tools. The authors are practising translators or translator trainers in the fields concerned. Although specialists, they explain their professional insights in a manner accessible to the wider learning public.

These books start from the recognition that professional translation practices require something more than elaborate abstraction or fixed methodologies. They are located close to work on authentic texts, and encourage learners to proceed inductively, solving problems as they arise from examples and case studies.

Each volume includes activities and exercises designed to help self-learners consolidate their knowledge; teachers may also find these useful for direct application in class, or alternatively as the basis for the design and preparation of their own material. Updated reading lists and website addresses will also help individual learners gain further insight into the realities of professional practice.

Dorothy Kelly
Series Editor



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Audiovisual Translation: Subtitling

Jorge Díaz Cintas & Aline Remael

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SysMedia and WinCAPS

SysMedia specialises in supplying software solutions to the television industry; including subtitling, teletext and interactive TV. The company has over 30 years' experience in the broadcast market, with customers worldwide including the BBC, Sky, and Technicolor.

WinCAPS is SysMedia's professional subtitling preparation software package, used for broadcast television around the world and for many of the latest multi-national DVD releases of many major Hollywood projects.

As with most SysMedia products, WinCAPS is designed with an emphasis on workflow automation and optimum productivity to make the subtitler's work quicker, easier and more productive. Today's software is a result of more than 25 years of experience in the design and development of subtitling systems. It uses the power of a modern multimedia PC to combine text processing with digital video playback to produce a convenient and easy-to-use subtitle creation package.

Its capabilities cover all languages and all forms of television subtitles for both live and recorded programming. It can be used equally well for burnt-in "open subtitling" (often associated with the sort of audiovisual translation covered by this book) as well as viewer-selectable "closed captioning" for the deaf and the hard-of-hearing.

WinCAPS is used not only for recorded television/DVD but also in the particularly demanding field of subtitling for live television programmes, including news and sports - enabling broadcasters to work both quickly and accurately. Automated tools include powerful newsroom data capture to avoid the need for real-time input and speech-text alignment for automatic transmission of short, scripted items. SysMedia also has invaluable expertise in how best to use speech recognition for a cost-efficient live subtitling service without compromising on accuracy.

As you will find from this book, translation for TV/DVD subtitling is a specialised field. WinCAPS helps make the task easier by allowing its user to concentrate on the language work rather than worry about the technicalities and restrictions of the medium. So you can prepare subtitles as quickly as possible and review them with the video just the same as their appearance on the finished DVD or TV broadcast.

The full version of WinCAPS features advanced options that can speed up timing by automatically matching the timing of each caption to the equivalent spoken text in the video.

The accompanying DVD contains a feature-restricted version of WinCAPS (licensed only for educational, non-commercial use). This provides a very good experience of the conventional modern approach to subtitling using software that is truly representative of the full commercial product. When the time comes, you will have already mastered the skills needed for commercial subtitling and you will be ready to make full use of WinCAPS for yourself.

Supplementary Resources Disclaimer

Additional resources were previously made available for this title on DVD. However, as DVD has become a less accessible format, all resources have been moved to a more convenient online download option.

You can find these resources available here: www.routledge.com/9781905763290

Please note: Where this title mentions the associated disc, please use the downloadable resources instead.

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How to Use this Book and DVD

The structure of *Audiovisual Translation: Subtitling*

This multimedia project is addressed to translation trainers, students, researchers, professionals, and all those interested in the practice and theory of subtitling. It consists of a book and an accompanying DVD, and is fundamentally interactive in its approach.

The publication can be used as a textbook by teachers as well as individuals wishing to master the fundamentals of subtitling on their own, and it offers a wealth of examples and different approaches to recurring subtitling issues that are of interest to professionals in the field. In addition, *Subtitling* raises a number of fundamental research questions and looks at some of the unresolved challenges of this very specific form of translation.

The fact that the book has been written in English shows its authors' intention for it to have a global reach. Writing for an international audience means that a degree of generalization is inevitable, whereas subtitling traditions vary from country to country and even from company to company. However, the degree of variation is relative and practices that were once fundamentally different are often beginning to converge. One could say that not only subtitling, but also audiovisual translation (AVT) generally is in a state of flux. This is due to a number of factors, which are all in one way or another related to the two-sided coin of globalization and glocalization, as well as technological developments. First of all, subtitlers worldwide communicate more than they used to at conferences, through professional organizations, and in journals devoted to translation in all its guises. Secondly, teaching in AVT is expanding, especially at university level. Furthermore, countries that are only beginning to develop some forms of AVT, such as subtitling for the deaf and audio description for the blind, and are still determining which way might be best suited for their needs, are looking to countries with longer traditions for examples and professional support. Finally, new technologies (the development of the DVD, for instance) and the advent of dedicated professional software for AVT also have a homogenizing function. The other side of the coin is that local traditions persist, as do differences related to the medium of dissemination, i.e. cinema, television, or DVD. Besides, relative newcomers on the market do not merely take on existing practices: their choice of AVT and its implementation are determined by their own needs, especially since the market for AVT, including subtitling, is expanding well beyond Europe.

In other words, a textbook that claims universality is certainly ambitious. Having said that, most differences in subtitling practice do not really affect the fundamentals of subtitling. Students who have acquired an insight into these fundamentals and the specific challenges of subtitling practice will be able to apply this knowledge and these skills in any context. Translation, whether for

the screen, the Internet or more traditional hard-copy publications will always remain a skill that requires flexibility and creativity. What is more, the different types of subtitling software available on the market may also be on the increase, but the software used in this book, WinCAPS, is well-established worldwide and includes all the functions typical of any professional subtitling software package.

Although written primarily in English, the project resorts to examples and exercises in a limited number of other languages, with back translation, in the book and on the DVD. Most of the exercises and clips included can be used as the basis for the creation of other pedagogical material in other languages, which means that the potential for practice is virtually unlimited. The location of the exercises and other materials on the DVD is always indicated as follows:

4.8.1 Go to DVD > Chapter 4 > Exercises > Exercise 4.8.1

This means that exercise 1, or the material needed for this first exercise, in section 8 of chapter 4 can be found on the DVD under ‘Chapter 4’, in the section entitled ‘Exercises’. See below for more information on the structure and map of the DVD.

The book

The book’s seven chapters offer a graded approach with exercises, discussion points and suggestions for research. The chapters in themselves and the book as a whole progress step-by-step, covering all major aspects of subtitling and the subtitling profession. Each chapter starts with a “Preliminary discussion” that aims at stimulating critical thinking, can be used for a warm-up session in class, lends a focus to the chapter, and presents an analytical interactive inroad into the subject matter. All the chapters are subdivided into sections that break down the issues tackled into their major components. They also contain numerous annotated examples taken from existing subtitled films and TV-programmes. All chapters end with discussion points and graded exercises. The discussion points test the users’ comprehension of the material covered, help them assimilate the information, offer suggestions for further research and invite students to compare or contrast the issues under discussion to the situation in their own part of the world. The exercises offer real subtitling practice, starting with some of the basic skills involved, without WinCAPS software, and gradually require the users to combine linguistic as well as technical and software-related skills. The various activities clearly state whether or not they involve material included on the DVD and where exactly on the DVD it can be found.

Chapter 1 offers a definition of subtitling, distinguishes subtitling from other forms of translation, and surveys the different types of subtitles and their classification on the basis of different parameters. It ends on a discussion of related translation types such as surtitles, intertitles and fansubs.

Chapter 2 deals with the subtitler's professional environments, taking into account that these may differ globally and are continually changing. Sub-topics are: the subtitling process, the different professionals involved in this process, and working conditions, including such matters as clients and rates, the influence of globalization, and the role of associations.

Chapter 3 on the semiotics of subtitling, contains the first hands-on exercises, but also provides essential information about the film as text, the complexity of the filmic sign, and how the subtitles interact with it. It includes practical information about the use and structure of screenplays and the specificities of film dialogue.

Chapter 4 focuses on technical issues: subtitling programs and what they can be expected to do, feet and frames, the advantages and disadvantages of dialogue lists, style guides, codes of good subtitling practice, and the spatial and temporal dimensions of subtitling. It also contains concrete instructions regarding the authors' preferred practice for the use of WinCAPS with respect to these matters. The authors' instructions are based on norms and guidelines currently applied today that are gaining increasing support in professional circles.

Chapter 5 is more grammatically oriented, dealing with punctuation and other textual conventions. Since such conventions are language and medium-bound, they can, of course, vary considerably. Due attention is devoted to this variation and to the way subtitling conventions may be evolving. The preferred approach for the exercises is again explained and illustrated with concrete examples. The conventions used in different text types such as dialogue, songs, letters and other written documents, as well as the rendering of numbers, abbreviations, symbols, measures, weights, etc. are also covered extensively.

Chapter 6 is devoted to the linguistics of subtitling in a broader sense and to subtitling as a form of rewriting that requires text reduction through condensation, reformulation and omission at word and/or sentence level. It discusses the syntactical as well as other grammatical and lexical challenges of this specific translation form. It also deals with segmentation and line breaks, offering ample examples of *dos* and *don'ts*.

Chapter 7 centres on more specific translation issues, some of which will be familiar to translators of other text types, but involve extra challenges in subtitling: linguistic variation and multilingualism, the translation of culture-bound items, humour and songs. The chapter ends with a discussion of a number of ideological issues.

Chapter 8, the final one, contains further activities aimed at exploiting

the subtitling program WinCAPS. Some of the exercises have been devised with particular tasks in mind, **WinCAPS activities**, whereas there is another subsection, **Extra scenes**, with digitized audiovisual excerpts in different languages for people interested in practising with this program in an independent way.

The book is completed with a **glossary** of terms used in the subtitling profession, a list of bibliographical as well as film **references** and an **index**.

The DVD

The contents of the accompanying DVD take up about 3.4 GB of disk space. The DVD will launch automatically and is subdivided into sections. The graphic survey of its structure is as follows:

- WinCAPS
 - Set-up
 - Initiation exercise
- Chapter 2
 - Discussion points
- Chapter 3
 - Examples
 - Exercises
- Chapter 4
 - Preliminary discussion
 - Examples
 - Exercises
- Chapter 5
 - Exercises
- Chapter 6
 - Discussion points
 - Exercises
- Chapter 7
 - Discussion points
 - Exercises
- Chapter 8
 - WinCAPS activities
 - Extra scenes in Dutch
 - Films – Documentaries
 - Extra scenes in English
 - Films – Documentaries – Animation films
 - Extra scenes in French
 - Films – Documentaries
 - Extra scenes in Italian
 - Films

Extra scenes in Spanish
Films – Documentaries
Appendices
Appendix 1 – Subtitling companies
Appendix 2 – Subtitling software programs
Appendix 3 – Websites of interest
Acknowledgements

The first main section contains the actual subtitling software WinCAPS as well as instructions on how to install it on your computer and use it. The following sections contain additional exercises linked to the different book chapters, with or without key. Chapter 8 on the DVD includes a section entitled **WinCAPS activities** containing exercises to be exploited with WinCAPS. Besides film clips and dialogue transcripts, you can also find WinCAPS files to work on and a key to these exercises. Instructions on how to work with these exercises can be found in the textbook itself. Subsequent sections contain extra filmic material in several languages (digitized scenes and dialogue transcripts) that can be exploited for exercises or just for practice. This material is not directly linked to any of the chapters and requires combined subtitling skills. The excerpts are from films and from documentary films shot in Dutch, English, French, Italian, and Spanish, giving the user the opportunity to work with other languages besides English.

Finally, the DVD also features a number of practical appendices with information about subtitling companies, software programs and useful websites. It concludes with a list of acknowledgements.

WinCAPS



One of the highlights of this multimedia project is the inclusion of WinCAPS, a professional subtitling software program developed by the company Sys-Media (www.sysmedia.com) and used by many television broadcasters and other subtitling facilities.

Your DVD contains a free release version of WinCAPS [go to: DVD > WinCAPS > Set-up]. In the same section of the DVD, the document entitled 'WinCAPS Installation instructions' states the minimum system requirements your computer must have and explains in a detailed way how to install the program on your PC.

Once you have successfully installed the program on your computer, you can start producing your own subtitles. To facilitate your first approach to WinCAPS, we suggest you start with the 'Initiation exercise' we propose on the DVD [go to: DVD > WinCAPS > Initiation exercise]. The 'Step by step subtitling guide' included in this section of your DVD takes you through the whole process of creating subtitles for a short scene called *Phone*, from the film *Charade*.

A more detailed and comprehensive manual on how to use WinCAPS can also be found on the DVD under the heading 'WinCAPS User Manual' [go to: DVD > WinCAPS > Set-up > WinCAPS User Manual]. Please bear in mind that the version you have with this project also allows the creation of subtitles for the deaf and the hard-of-hearing. You will not need to use some of the functions.

In order to speed up subtitling production, most subtitling software programs offer the option of carrying out certain tasks by means of keyboard shortcuts. A list of the most productive shortcuts to work with WinCAPS can also be found on your DVD [go to: DVD > WinCAPS > Set-up > WinCAPS Keyboard shortcuts].

Restrictions in this version of WinCAPS

Important: The 'Educational' version of WinCAPS supplied has been specially produced for the DVD of this multimedia project and is not licensed for commercial use.

Working with this version of WinCAPS you will be able to carry out all tasks pertaining to subtitling on your computer, but you will be limited to a maximum of 75 subtitles.

You will be saving your work to files with a .w30 extension, the same way as a word document has a .doc extension at the end. This extension is created automatically, is unique to this educational version of WinCAPS, and means that any .w30 files created with this version of WinCAPS are incompatible with the commercial version of WinCAPS or any other subtitling programs.

When you retrieve any work that you have previously saved (as a .w30 file) you will notice that the timecode values are only restored to within 10

frames or so of their previous value. Timecode values in files are frame accurate during an operating session (however long that may be) and when opening the example files provided on the DVD itself. This restriction can be removed by purchasing a licence. Please contact SysMedia for details and special offers for tutors.

Many of the more advanced features of the normal WinCAPS software have also been disabled (such as file export, shot change detection, visual audio indication, shortforms and text splitting). To upgrade to a commercial software version you should contact SysMedia directly: www.sysmedia.com.

Example WinCAPS files on the DVD

Activities in Chapter 8 ask you to work with clips and read-only .w30 files containing subtitles that have been created for you to correct. These .w30 files and the corresponding clips will be automatically loaded onto your computer hard drive [C:\Example Books] when you install WinCAPS. In order to work with these files and clips, you will have to open WinCAPS first and retrieve them from your hard drive as indicated in Chapter 8. You will have to create a working copy of the read-only .w30 files. For more details go to DVD > WinCAPS > Set-up > WinCAPS Installation Instructions.

Video Playback Difficulties (Codecs)

If you experience any audio or video playback difficulties when opening any of the clips on this DVD (e.g. you can only hear the soundtrack of the clip but cannot see the image), then it is possible that the computer you are working with is using an incompatible codec. The solution might be to install more codecs in your computer. You can download some, like:

ACE Mega CoDecS Pack 6.03

Coda Codec Pack

Codec Pack All in 1 6.0.3.0.

These are all a free collection of codecs (coders/decoders), media player filters, media players and other utilities for video watching, audio and video processing, which you will find useful. They are all easily found on Internet. Alternatively please consult the WinCAPS support section of the SysMedia website (www.sysmedia.com).

We very much hope that you will enjoy reading the book and using the DVD and software, and that it will reveal all of subtitling's secrets for you.

Good luck!

Jorge Díaz Cintas & Aline Remael

January 2007

1. Introduction to Subtitling

1.0 Preliminary discussion

- 1.1 Do you see subtitling as a case of translation or adaptation?
What are your reasons for your choice?
- 1.2 In your opinion, does it matter whether subtitling is perceived one way or another?
- 1.3 Make a list of situations where subtitles are consumed in your country.

The main aim of this book is to introduce the reader to subtitling, one of the most thriving areas within the wider discipline of Translation Studies. For many years ignored by academics and teachers alike, it has since the 1990s gained well-deserved visibility thanks to the proliferation and distribution of audiovisual materials in our society. The value of the image is of crucial importance in our daily lives and we are literally surrounded by screens of all shapes and sizes. Television sets, cinemas, computers, and mobile phones are a common and recurrent feature of our social environment, based on the power of the screen. We come across them at home, in our work place, on public transport, in libraries, bars, restaurants and cinemas. We spend a fair amount of hours watching screens and consuming audiovisual programmes to carry out our work, to develop and enhance our professional and academic careers, to enjoy ourselves and to obtain information. It would not be an exaggeration to talk about the ubiquity of the image in our time and age.

A common companion of the image since the 1930s has been the word, and with the word comes the need for translation. Scholars like Gambier (1994) and Díaz Cintas (1999) differentiate up to 10 different ways of translating audiovisual programmes, although there are three main ones: dubbing (also known as lip-sync), subtitling and voice-over. This chapter sets out to offer a definition of subtitling practice as well as a classification of the many different types of subtitles that we come across in our daily lives.

1.1 Definition

Subtitling may be defined as a translation practice that consists of presenting a written text, generally on the lower part of the screen, that endeavours to recount the original dialogue of the speakers, as well as the discursive elements that appear in the image (letters, inserts, graffiti, inscriptions, placards, and the like), and the information that is contained on the soundtrack (songs, voices off). In some languages, like Japanese, cinema subtitles are presented

vertically and tend to appear on the right-hand side of the screen.

All subtitled programmes are made up of three main components: the spoken word, the image and the subtitles. The interaction of these three components, along with the viewer's ability to read both the images and the written text at a particular speed, and the actual size of the screen, determine the basic characteristics of the audiovisual medium. Subtitles must appear in synchrony with the image and dialogue, provide a semantically adequate account of the SL dialogue, and remain displayed on screen long enough for the viewers to be able to read them.

1.2 Translation or adaptation?

Audiovisual Translation (AVT)

For some, this activity falls short of being a case of translation proper because of all the spatial and temporal limitations imposed by the medium itself (§4) which constrain the end result. They prefer to talk about adaptation – an attitude that has stymied the debate about AVT and could be tainted as having been one of the main reasons why the whole area has been traditionally ignored by scholars in translation until very recently.

Audiovisual programmes use two codes, image and sound, and whereas literature and poetry evoke, films represent and actualize a particular reality based on specific images that have been put together by a director. Thus, subtitling – dubbing and voice-over too – is constrained by the respect it owes to synchrony in these new translational parameters of image and sound (subtitles should not contradict what the characters are doing on screen), and time (i.e. the delivery of the translated message should coincide with that of the original speech). In addition, subtitles entail a change of mode from oral to written and resort frequently to the omission of lexical items from the original. As far as space is concerned, the dimensions of the actual screen are finite and the target text will have to accommodate to the width of the screen. Although the figures vary, this means that a subtitle will have some 32 to 41 characters per line in a maximum of two lines. These tend to be the main reasons put forward by those who have looked down on this activity, considering it as a type of adaptation rather than translation. It is indeed this attitude that can be held responsible “for the fact that translation studies of all disciplines have been rather reluctant to include film translation among their subjects of study” (Delabastita 1989:213). For others, this concept of adaptation seems to equate the process to a lesser activity and becomes enough of an excuse to carry out a linguistic transfer that is clearly inadequate but nonetheless justified since it is only a case of adaptation.

Jakobson (1959) is often cited as being one of the first academics to open up the field. He famously established three types of translation: intralingual

(or rewording), interlingual (or translation proper) and intersemiotic (or transmutation). Half a century later, this may need some revision to accommodate other dimensions, crucially the audio and visual ones in our case, but the essence is there.

One of the first significant advances in the process of conceding theoretical kudos to translated products such as audiovisuals came from the hand of Reiss (1977 and 1981). Basing herself on the three basic language functions devised by psychologist Karl Bühler, Reiss identifies in a first instance three types of texts (informative, expressive and operative) that encompass the different language functions. In an effort to acknowledge translation forms considered until then marginal, Reiss (1977:111) points out the special attention deserved by written texts co-existing with other sign systems with which they must maintain a constant link. To make room in her taxonomy for this new group of texts of greater semiotic complexity, Reiss creates an additional hyper-text type which she calls 'audio-medial text type'. She defines it as a superstructure that takes into account the special characteristics of the spoken language and oral communication, and sits above the three basic communicative situations and corresponding text types. Despite the fact that the examples provided by Reiss (*ibid.*), "songs, comic strips, advertisements, medieval morality ballads, etc.", seem to overlook audiovisual translation as such, it is evident that it fully fits into her theoretical framework.

Some years later, Delabastita (1989:214), aware of the risks involved in having a limited and normative definition of translation that "is in danger of being applicable to very few, well-selected cases, and of being unsuitable for a description of most actual fact," rejects this minimal kind of definition and opts for a highly flexible notion. He is representative of a trend and an approach that is also shared by Mayoral Asensio (2001b:46), who goes even further by advocating a more dynamic notion:

The definition of the object of study in translation studies is not the definition of a natural process that assumes an unchanging nature; rather it is the definition of a technological process that continually evolves and changes. Our role is not to close the door on new realities but to favour and encourage them. We need open definitions that can be modified both to envelop new realities (sign language interpretation, multimedia, text production), and to get rid of those that have ceased to be useful and necessary. (Our translation)

We share this opinion. Translation must be understood from a more flexible, heterogeneous and less static perspective, one that encompasses a broad set of empirical realities and acknowledges the ever-changing nature of practice. The traditional notion of formal fidelity, so venerated by the structuralists of

the 1960s, has now been revised and made all translations more flexible, but this is especially the case of subtitling and other forms of audiovisual translation. The one-to-one translation approach loses all validity in our field and the concept of formal equivalence must be understood from a much more flexible perspective than in other spheres of translation. If we reject the term ‘adaptation’, it is because it seems to have taken on a negative connotation, with some academics using it to take away ontological value from this professional practice which they see as inferior to translation. Gambier (1994:278) also considers the use of this all-encompassing epigraph inappropriate, since the mention of adaptation implies, in his words, “to be under the spell of a quantitative, mathematical theory of information (information entropy) which considers cross-linguistic communication in terms of losses or additions and sees translation as a process of mimetically copying a literary word, a duty to repeat”. Nearly a decade later, Gambier (2003:178-179) seems to somehow backtrack in his argument when he resorts to the term ‘transadaptation’. Although the concept is not clearly defined, it is used in an attempt to justify the hybrid nature characterizing all the different audiovisual translation types, and can be perceived as yet another effort to grant translation status, even if only partially, to our field. The term is probably better suited to give account of another professional practice, in the way Neves (2005:151-154) defines it. She uses the term:

to refer to a subtitling solution that implies the *translation* of messages from different verbal and non-verbal acoustic codes into verbal and/or non-verbal visual codes; and the *adaptation* of such visual codes to the needs of people with hearing impairment so as to guarantee readability and thus greater accessibility (ibid.:154).

We believe, however, that the battle has now been won with regard to the nature of these practices and translation is perceived by most scholars as a more flexible and inclusive term, capable of accommodating new realities rather than disregarding practices that do not fit into a corseted, outdated notion of a term coined many centuries ago, when the cinema, the television and the computer had not yet been invented.

Once we have accepted the tenet that we are indeed dealing with cases of translation, the following step is to find a generic term that can encompass all the different manifestations we find in the audiovisual realm. Although this may sound an easy task, the fact is that the terminology used is very hesitant and can be confusing. The adjectives ‘constrained’ and ‘subordinate’ were regularly used when referring to this type of translation in publications during the 1980s and early 1990s, but began soon to receive criticism for their somewhat negative connotations. It was then that the term ‘audiovisual

translation', abbreviated to AVT, appeared in academic circles. This coinage has the advantage of including the semiotic dimension, and has taken root to such an extent that today its use is quite frequent. However, despite its popularity, it is not the only term used and some scholars prefer other terms such as 'film translation' or 'cinema translation', but as the field of study spreads to other types of programmes – e.g. sitcoms, documentaries, cartoons, etc. – these concepts also become somewhat restricting. Other umbrella terms, all of them bringing in different nuances, are also in use. One that has caught on in English but not so much in other languages is 'screen translation', which strives to encompass all products distributed on screen, be it a television, movie or computer screen. This term opens the doors to the translation of other products that until now have failed to make it to a more stringent classification, such as computer games, web pages and CD-ROMs. Another designation that is gaining ground is 'multimedia translation', to refer to those products where the message is broadcast through multiple media and channels. This term blurs the boundaries even further and establishes a stronger link with the localization of software and the translation of programmes that are distributed on the Internet, as does the more recent 'multidimensional translation'.

This fluctuation in terms is no more than a reflection of the changing times in which we live. Far from representing a barrier to communication, it could be interpreted as a clear sign of the desire of many academics to maintain an open and flexible approach to our object of study; one that can assimilate and acknowledge the new realities emerging in the translation world.

Fortunately enough, one of the terms, audiovisual translation (AVT), has been gaining ground in recent years and is fast becoming the standard referent. In its inception, AVT was used to encapsulate different translation practices used in the audiovisual media – cinema, television, VHS – in which there is a transfer from a source to a target language, which involves some form of interaction with sound and images. Dubbing and subtitling are the most popular in the profession and the best known by audiences, but there are others such as voice-over, partial-dubbing, narration and interpreting. The translation of live performance was added to this taxonomy at a later stage and that is how surtitling for the opera and the theatre has also come to be included.

New and innovative professional activities such as subtitling for the deaf and the hard-of-hearing (SDH) and audio description for the blind and the partially sighted (AD) are also making a place for themselves within AVT. These new practices have brought in further terminological disarray, especially because of the fact that none of them, at the beginning at least, implied the transfer from a source to a target language, one of the traditionally defining features of any translation activity. Nevertheless, the majority of scholars and practitioners in our field have embraced SDH and AD as an integral part of AVT. The wider concept of accessibility has been put forward

to help bridge any possible divides (Díaz Cintas 2005b). In societies that aim at being more just and inclusive, accessibility has a social function and means making an audiovisual programme available to people that otherwise could not have access to it. In this sense, to lip-sync, to subtitle or to voice-over a programme shares as much the idea of accessibility as SDH or AD. Only the intended audiences are different. Whether the hurdle is a language or a sensorial barrier, the aim of the translation process is exactly the same: to facilitate access to an otherwise hermetic source of information and entertainment. In this way, accessibility becomes a common denominator that underpins these practices.

Finally, computer games and interactive software programmes are taking subtitling to the borders between AVT and localization since these games travel not only subtitled, but also adapted to the cultural sensibilities of the target gamers. Likewise, subtitling is re-entering the domain of speech when summarizing techniques and interpreting are combined in teletext subtitling for the deaf and hearing impaired through voice recognition. These trends are representative of a broader move: different forms of audiovisual translation and other translation modes are converging, creating new hybrid forms and sometimes catering for very different and well-defined target audiences. The key word for successful audiovisual translation is insight and understanding of the product and its expected function, combined with desire to learn and willingness to adapt.

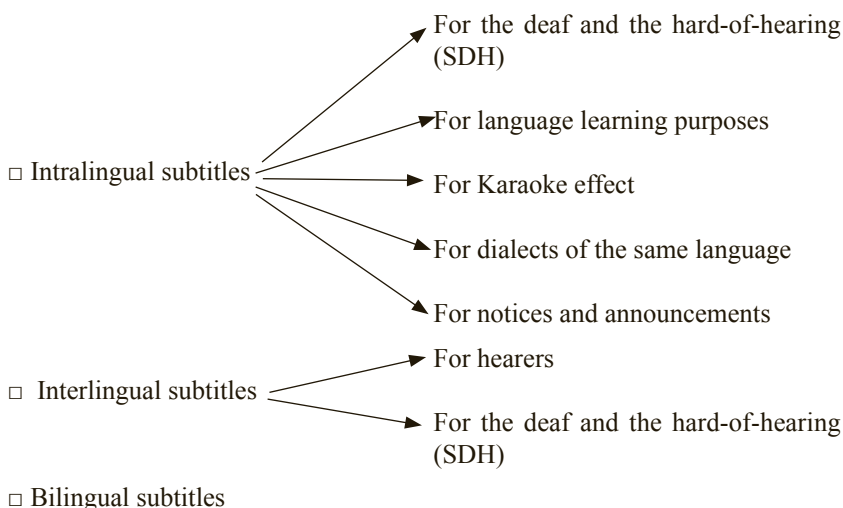
1.3 Classification of subtitles

Different typologies of subtitles can be established depending on the criteria that are used at the onset. Subtitling has a very close relationship with technology and one of the main problems encountered when trying to come up with a fixed classification of subtitles is the speed at which technological developments take place. No sooner has one classification been made than new types of subtitles appear on the market.

In an attempt to offer a comprehensive overview of the many different types of subtitles in existence, we have decided to group them according to the following five criteria: linguistic, time available for preparation, technical, methods of projection, and distribution format.

1.3.1 Linguistic parameters

One of the most traditional classifications of subtitles focuses on the linguistic dimension. From this perspective, we can find the following types:



Intralingual subtitling involves a shift from oral to written but stays always within the same language, hence the reluctance of some to call it translation. The first type, SDH, is primarily aimed at people who are deaf and people with a hearing impairment, in order to ensure greater democratic access to audiovisual programming. This variety is also known as (closed) captioning in American English. On television, these subtitles are broadcast by means of an independent signal activated only by those interested in accessing pages 888 or 777 of teletext in most European countries. In North America they are transmitted on what is known as line 21. The oral content of the actors' dialogues is converted into written speech, which is presented in subtitles of up to three, or occasionally four, lines. They generally change colour on television depending on the person who is talking or the emphasis given to certain words within the same subtitle. Besides the dialogues, they also incorporate all paralinguistic information that contributes to the development of the plot or to the creation of atmosphere, which a deaf person cannot access from the soundtrack, e.g. the irony of a statement, a telephone ringing, laughter, applause, a knock on the door, the sound of an engine, and the like. Although they are usually presented at the bottom of the screen, they lend themselves more to physical manipulation, as it is possible to move them to the left or right of the screen when it is necessary to identify speakers or to make clear where the sound is coming from.

SDH is undoubtedly one of the forms of audiovisual communication which is developing most at present, thanks to the success achieved by pressure groups campaigning for the interests of this sector of the audience. The fruit of their work is evident from the announcement of new legislation in many countries obliging television channels to broadcast a certain percentage of

their programmes with this type of subtitles. The European Year of Disabled People in 2003 helped in great measure to give increased visibility to the issue of accessibility to audiovisual media, particularly in those countries that had been lagging behind (see also Neves 2005). As far as television broadcasting is concerned, the volume of SDH has undergone spectacular growth in recent years. The BBC (British Broadcasting Corporation) is, without a doubt, on a global level, one of the most advanced in this area, having pledged to broadcast 100% of their programming with subtitles for the deaf and hard-of-hearing by 2008. In Canada, the Global Television Network has been subtitling all its programming, twenty-four hours a day, seven days a week, since January 2005. In Spain, the public television station TVE subtitled some 550 hours in 1999, while four years later the number of hours was in the region of 2,500. In 2003, TVE increased its subtitled programming by 73% compared to the previous year (Moreno Latorre 2003). The DVD has also exploited the potential of this type of subtitling and has made it more widely accessible. On a pedagogical note, few educational institutions offer programmes of study that focus on this type of subtitling, and the field is still to be developed.

A second group of intralingual subtitles are those specifically devised as a didactic tool for the teaching and learning of foreign languages. This function of interlingual subtitles has long been recognized. In an article published as early as 1974, Dollerup was already highlighting the didactic value of interlingual subtitles as a language learning tool and stating that in Denmark “many people must [...] be using foreign programmes as a means for keeping up, possibly even improving their command of foreign languages” (ibid.: 197). Watching and listening to films and programmes subtitled from other languages helps us not only to develop and expand our linguistic skills, but also to contextualize the language and culture of other countries. We familiarize ourselves with the foreign language through the soundtrack (vocabulary, intonation, pronunciation), and the images bring us into contact with the mannerisms and behaviours of other cultures (gesticulation, way of dressing, interpersonal relationships, geographical spaces). It is precisely this unique possibility of having direct access to the original and being able to compare it with its translation that has been stressed by many theoreticians as one of the most positive additional bonuses of subtitling (D’Ydewalle and Pavakanum 1992; Koolstra and Beentjes 1999).

But, to return to intralingual subtitling, it can be argued that SDH also offers great educational potential to people with limited knowledge of a country’s language, e.g. immigrants and foreign students, but the fact is that it is not openly targeted at these social groups. Many scholars have discussed the issue (Danan 1992 and 2004, Vanderplank 1988 and 1992). Some firms and distribution companies have recognized this educational potential, seen a niche in the market and responded with their own initiatives. Columbia Tristar Home Video, for example, was one of the first companies in the 1990s

to launch a collection of English language film videos with English subtitles entitled *SpeakUp*. Viewers were thus able to read on the screen the written dialogue of the actors and recognize or confirm what they had not understood aurally. The conventions applied in this type of subtitling differ substantially from those followed in interlingual subtitling, and it is not uncommon to find subtitles of three lines, full of lexical repetitions and incomplete sentences that are a literal transcription, word for word, of the dialogues, putting some pressure on reading speed. The Spanish newspaper *El País* also jumped on board, in collaboration with Disney, with its collection *Diviértete con el inglés* [Have Fun with English]. Over several months in 2002, many classics from Disney were distributed on video in their original English format with English subtitles so that young people could become familiar with the English language in an enjoyable way.

Although, by and large, the only movies that come onto the market with this type of subtitling are in English, other languages and institutions do seem to be awaking to the attraction exerted by the audiovisual world and the potential it offers for exporting their language and culture. Television has not been immune to these experiments and the international French channel, *France 5*, has for years been broadcasting some of its programmes in French with open subtitles also in French, in order to promote the learning of the language.

The arrival of DVD has also meant the consolidation of didactic subtitles, as a track distinct to and independent from that of SDH. Their use is not confined to helping foreigners learn languages, but can also be an aid to children in consolidating their mother tongues, given that many societies are now so thoroughly immersed in the world of the image and audiovisual communication. Big distributors like Disney and Paramount have for some time been marketing a number of their DVDs with two tracks of subtitles in English: one for the deaf and another which is didactic. Again, to date English is the only language in which this dual subtitling is found on DVD, although the situation might well change in the future.

A third type of intralingual subtitling that is gaining tremendous popularity nowadays is known as karaoke. It is generally used with songs or movie musicals so that the public can sing along at the same time as the characters on screen. The movie *The Sound of Music* has been advertised for many years in a central London cinema as follows: "The classic film musical, now with subtitles so everyone can join in!" It has been a tremendous hit, consistently sold out, and has initiated a tradition with the intralingual subtitling of other movies and programmes such as *The Rocky Horror Picture Show*, *Abba Live in Concert*, and *Joseph and the Amazing Technicolor Dreamcoat*.

Another example of intralingual subtitling is the use of subtitles in movies and programmes for the dialogues of people whose accents are difficult to understand for audiences who, in principle, share the same language. Languages that are spoken far and wide throughout the world, such as English,

Spanish, or French, are those that are commonly affected. But other lesser spoken languages also transcribe the dialogues. On Flemish television in Belgium intralingual subtitles are often used to ‘translate’ linguistic variants that the producer of a particular programme feels will not be understood by the entire population. This means that not only are some Dutch programmes from the Netherlands intralingually subtitled on Flemish television, but also some TV series, and parts of reality shows, whenever a character or speaker uses a (regional) Flemish variant that may not be understood by the entire Flemish community, due to phonetic or lexical variation. The language used in these subtitles is standard Dutch, which means that all *couleur locale* is lost. The desirability of such subtitling is the topic of much debate (Vandekerckhove *et al.* 2006).

Although rare, this strategy can be used throughout an entire programme. One such example is the British film *Trainspotting*, where the actors speak English with such a strong Scottish accent that the movie was distributed in the United States with English subtitles. However, the common practice is to resort to these subtitles only in sporadic cases where there is a need to transcribe utterances from people who speak the language either as a foreign language or as their native language, but with a strong, local accent and lexical variation that makes it difficult to understand for the rest of the speakers of that language.

The fifth and last category of intralingual subtitling can be seen on monitors in underground stations and other public areas where subtitles are used for advertising, as well as for broadcasting the latest news. The use of written texts on screen allows the information to be transmitted without sound, so as not to disturb the public.

The other major type of subtitling falls under the category of interlingual, and implies the translation from a source to a target language. Gottlieb (1994) calls it ‘diagonal subtitling’ since it involves a shift from one language to another along with a change of mode, from oral to written. This subtitling is the main focus of this book and will be analyzed in depth in the chapters to follow.

The traditional, broad distinction between interlingual (for hearers) and intralingual (for the deaf) subtitling has systematically overlooked a professional practice that has existed for several years and that is acquiring greater visibility thanks to DVD: interlingual subtitles for the deaf and the hearing impaired. Historically, in countries with a strong tradition of dubbing, such as Spain, Germany, Austria, France or Italy, the deaf could only watch programmes that had been originally produced in Spanish, German, French or Italian, and later also subtitled intralingually into these languages. Given that the translating custom of these five countries favours the dubbing of the vast majority of programmes imported from other countries, it has been difficult for the deaf and hard-of-hearing to access the information contained in these

programmes and they have had to content themselves with the few foreign ones to be broadcast with subtitles. In other countries with a stronger subtitling tradition like for instance Portugal, Greece or the Scandinavian nations, the deaf have normally been served by the same interlingual subtitles as the hearing viewers, even when these have clearly been inappropriate to their needs since they do not incorporate the paralinguistic information necessary for the deaf to be able to contextualize the action.

However, with the arrival of the DVD the situation has changed and is continuing to change radically. Pressure groups in countries such as Germany, UK and Italy have managed to get many foreign films marketed in their countries with two different tracks of interlingual subtitles: one for the hearing population and a second one that addresses the needs of the deaf. We now have many American films that have two subtitle tracks in Italian and German – one for the hearing and another for the deaf and the hard-of-hearing. This is also the case with films like the Spanish *Women on the Verge of a Nervous Breakdown*, which is sold on DVD with two interlingual subtitle tracks in English and a further two in German. Unfortunately, these are to date the only three languages making full use of interlingual SDH. The rest seem to lag behind in these new developments. Although all languages are supposed to be equal in principle, it would appear that in the film and DVD industries, English, German and Italian are ‘more equal’ than the other languages in regard to SDH. Strangest of all is that it is generally the same distributor who markets the films in all countries, which makes it hard to understand why some languages can have two subtitle tracks and others just one. Only through pressure groups campaigning for the interests of these sectors of the population can social advances aimed at facilitating access to all media in all languages for everybody be achieved.

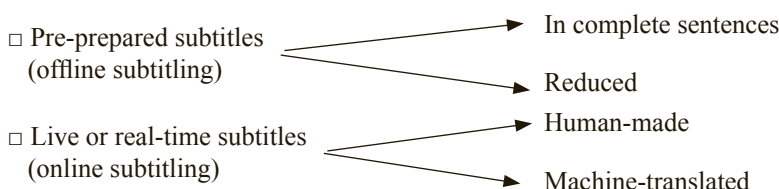
Bilingual subtitles are the third type within this category and are produced in geographical areas where two languages are spoken. In Belgium, in an attempt to satisfy the Walloon and Flemish communities, subtitles in the cinema are in French and Flemish. In Finland, where Swedish is an official language on a par with Finnish, bilingualism is also respected in certain regions and television and cinema resort to subtitles in both languages. Outside Europe, in countries such as Jordan and Israel, Hebrew and Arabic co-exist at the bottom of the screen. In these cases, the two lines available for subtitles are in constant use, each one dedicated to a different language. To avoid excessive pollution of the image, they tend to use only two-liners, although subtitles of four lines may also be found. The additional pressure on space renders bilingual subtitling an endeavour that borders on the unattainable.

Another setting where bilingual subtitles are resorted to is in international film festivals. In order to attract a wider audience, many of these festivals screen their foreign films – say Iranian, Spanish or Japanese – with two sets of subtitles. One set is in English, to satisfy the needs of an international au-

dience made up of film directors, producers, distributors, actors, and viewers who come from all corners of the world, and the other set of subtitles is in the language of the country where the film festival takes place, e.g. French in Cannes, German in Berlin, and Italian in Venice.

1.3.2 Time available for preparation

By looking at subtitles from this perspective, the following types can be distinguished:



The main difference between these two categories resides in the fact that the pre-prepared subtitles are done after the programme has been shot and some time ahead of its broadcasting or release, giving translators ample time to carry out their work; whereas the online type is performed live, i.e. at the same time as the original programme is taking place or being broadcast.

Pre-prepared subtitles can be subdivided further according to their lexical density. Subtitling in complete sentences, within the limits imposed by the medium, is the most commonly used and the one we normally consume when watching a programme with subtitles. The reduced variety is used when translating television programmes such as the news, interviews or documentaries in which only the gist of what is being said is deemed to be relevant for the audience and translated.

Live or real-time subtitling, also known as simultaneous or online, is a relatively new type, only used when there has not been time to prepare the subtitles in advance, as in the case of live interviews, political statements, sports programmes or news bulletins. This type is much more common in intralingual subtitling for the deaf, but it is also occasionally done interlingually. In the latter case, it is usually done by a team of professionals involving a professional interpreter, who translates the message in a condensed way and in front of a microphone connected to the headphones of a velotypist or stenographer. This is a professional who types in shorthand rather than letters on a special keyboard and can achieve the speed and accuracy required for live subtitling. Irrespective of the linguistic difficulty posed by the source text, this is a very complex activity in which complicated mental processes must take place in seconds. There is also the pressure of coordinating the efforts of several professionals working under stressful conditions, which justifies why this approach

is being abandoned in favour of voice recognition. Describing the way it is done in the Netherlands, Den Boer (2001:168) writes: “subtitling involves the very close and concentrated cooperation of two subtitlers-interpreters, one velotypist and, in complicated cases, an editor”. Synchrony between source and target texts is the biggest problem here. As subtitles can only be written after the original dialogue has been uttered, this inevitably leads to a delay and lack of synchrony between the dialogues and the subtitles, which can be confusing for the viewer.

Intralingual real-time subtitling is a daily occurrence in countries with a tradition in SDH and it is carried out following two different approaches. In a similar fashion to the previous type, but without the need for an interpreter, a stenographer or stenotypist – known in North America as stenocaptioner – is in charge of writing the subtitles using the keyboards and writing theories common in court reporting (Robson 2004:119-148). The other approach to live subtitling is to use speech recognition software. It is a simple enough process whereby a person dictates the speech to a microphone, connected to a computer and to a speech recognition program that converts speech into written text. Although the technology has been around since the 1990s, the relatively high number of spelling mistakes that make it to the screen is one of the main drawbacks of this approach. The fact that speech recognition programs only work with a very small number of major languages, simply because more research efforts have been put into them, also makes them impractical in the case of most languages. There are still many other hurdles that need to be overcome before this technology can be put to a successful end (Robson 2004:149-160). However, the industry wants to see it work properly and is investing large sums of money in its development, leading some people like Robson (*ibid.*:151) to state: “it’s only a matter of time before speech-based captioning systems are more broadly deployed”.

Technology and subtitling go hand in hand, and machine translation undertaken in interlingual subtitling, without the apparent input of human beings, has for some years been a reality in the USA, in an attempt to attract viewers from certain minority groups. This kind of instantaneous translation into several languages makes use of material that is already available in English. The USA has a long history of subtitling for the deaf and the hard-of-hearing, which is reflected in some pioneering legislation in this field and in high percentages of audiovisual programmes captioned intralingually – i.e. from English to English – for these social groups. Using these subtitles in English and an automatic translation program, the company Global Translation Inc.’s (www.translatetv.com) has been the first to provide instant machine translation of television content from English into Spanish. Judging by the awards it has received and the enthusiasm it appears to have awakened in certain sectors of the profession, it would not be surprising if, in the not too distant future, this practice were to awaken greater interest in other countries with

multicultural and multilingual populations. Despite its potential, however, the problem here resides in the apparent lack of human agents and in the fact that this approach seems to be driven solely by economic forces and interests, as is apparent from the company's own website: "The use of the TTV service provides broadcasters with a cost effective way to reach the Hispanic viewer while also generating additional incremental advertising revenue". Quality seems to be disregarded altogether and the results are still a long way from being satisfactory. If the examples shown on their website are meant to be the flagship of their trade, the situation becomes worrying. Subtitles such as these two from their website:

ESO ES LA PRESENTACION ENTERA.
Y ESO ES EXACTAMENTE QUE LO
HICIMOS AQUI.
[THAT IS THE ENTIRE PRESENTATION.
AND THAT IS EXACTLY THAT WE
DID IT HERE.]

Ningunas muertes reportaron con
esos incidentes, sin embargo.
[None deaths reported with
those incidents, however.]

are not only lexically and syntactically incorrect in Spanish, but also nonsensical. With their very peculiar grammar, riddled with interferences from English, they are an attack on the Spanish language and do very little to educate their readers.

1.3.3 Technical parameters

From a technical perspective, the following two types of subtitles can be identified:

- ☐ Open subtitles
- ☐ Closed subtitles

The basic difference between them is that, in the first case, the subtitles are burned or projected onto the image and cannot be removed or turned off. The programme and the subtitles cannot be disassociated from each other, allowing the viewer no choice as to their presence on screen. In the second case, the translation can be added to the programme at the viewer's will. The subtitles are hidden and can only be seen with an appropriate decoder or when the viewer activates them on DVD.

Until the arrival of DVD, interlingual subtitles were always open on television, in the cinemas, and distributed with the old VHS tape. Intralingual subtitles, on the other hand, were always closed and broadcast via teletext or line 21. With the DVD, a much more versatile format, the situation has changed and we can now also find closed interlingual subtitles, whose appearance on screen is optional and dependent on the viewer. However, contrary to general belief, not all subtitling on DVD is closed and some companies, perhaps rather surprisingly, do distribute their films on DVD with open subtitles.

1.3.4 Methods of projecting subtitles

A classification of subtitles from this perspective represents in effect an excursus through the history of subtitling:

- ☐ Mechanical and thermal subtitling
- ☐ Photochemical subtitling
- ☐ Optical subtitling
- ☐ Laser subtitling
- ☐ Electronic subtitling

The technical process of transferring the subtitles to the actual film or programme has undergone a considerable evolution, which has led to an improvement in their presentation and stability on screen. We will focus on the last two types, but for those interested Ivarsson and Carroll (1998:12-19) and Díaz Cintas (2001a:101-103) offer a more detailed account of each of them.

The current method of impression most commonly used in cinema subtitling is laser. Introduced in the 1980s, it rapidly proved itself to be much more effective than the previous methods it began to replace. A laser ray of great precision burns the emulsion of the positive copy while printing the subtitle which, thanks to the time code, is exactly synchronized with the actors' speech. From this point the subtitles form an integral part of the film copy, and every time it is projected they will appear on the lower part of the screen. Since they are burned in they are always white, like the screen onto which they are projected. This method permits excellent definition of letters, with enhanced contours that facilitate the legibility of the text. Being actually printed on the copy eliminates any possibility of the subtitles moving or shaking during the projection of the film. To laser subtitle a full-length feature film takes about ten times the film's projection time.

Electronic subtitling is the other method frequently used in the profession as an alternative to laser subtitling, its greatest advantage being that it allows subtitles to be superimposed on the screen instead of being engraved on the image. The subtitles are produced by a character generator and beamed by a projector onto the screen. The technology uses a time code system to ensure

that the text is projected in synchrony with the film. Electronic subtitling permits extremely versatile subtitling of a single film print, making it possible to project the subtitles onto (or below) the image, in any language, in any colour (though they tend to be white or yellow), and without damaging the original copy. It is cheaper than laser engraving and is used mainly in film festivals where a single copy of the film can be shown with various sets of subtitles in several countries. The other advantage over laser is that since electronic subtitles are independent of the audiovisual programme, they can easily be revised and modified from projection to projection.

This system seems to provide better access to movies screened in the cinema for people with hearing loss, without imposing on the hearing population as the subtitles may be projected onto a screen adjacent to the movie screen. It is also a solution for cinemas that want to use one and the same film print for alternative screenings with and without SDH. Electronic subtitling is also preferred in television and DVD.

1.3.5 Distribution format

A fifth and last category can be established according to the medium used for the distribution of the programme, which may affect the way subtitles are produced. Thus, subtitles can be made for the following:

- ☐ Cinema
- ☐ Television
- ☐ Video, VHS
- ☐ DVD
- ☐ Internet

Although the conventions applied when subtitling a programme will ultimately depend on individual companies, on the instructions given by the client or on the subtitling program being used, there are some differences from medium to medium. We mention here some of the most striking ones, but a more detailed discussion is found in chapters 4 and 5.

To calculate the reading speed and the time a subtitle can stay on screen, some companies have traditionally applied what is known in the profession as ‘the six-second rule’, which refers to the time it takes the average viewer to read and assimilate the information contained in the two lines of a subtitle, when each line consists of some 35 or 37 characters. The average viewer is, therefore, able to read 70 to 74 characters in 6 seconds and from this main rule we can then calculate the amount of text we can write in shorter subtitles (§4.7.9). However, this calculation seems to be mostly used when subtitling for television and varies when subtitling for other media like cinema, video,

DVD or Internet. The reading speed applied in the other media is normally faster, the reason being that the profile of the television viewer is in general more heterogeneous and the subtitles have to satisfy all viewers.

As far as the line length is concerned, cinemas may use up to a maximum of 40 or 41 characters – 43 at some film festivals – since it is an accepted norm in the profession that the viewer is able to read subtitles more easily and quickly on a cinema than on a television screen. Although this has not been thoroughly investigated, the reasons seem to be the better definition and larger screen dimensions, the cultural profile of the audience, and the greater concentration that movie theatres afford viewers. DVD also tends to go for these long lines, as viewers can simply rewind the movie if they have not had enough time to read a subtitle. The other reason given is that consumers of DVDs – who also have access to the dubbed version and can choose the language combination of their liking for the sound and subtitle tracks – often use subtitles to improve their skills in other languages and prefer a translation that follows the original more closely and abridges as little as possible. Television, on the other hand, varies from as little as 28 characters per line to some 37 as the maximum. With new technological advances, the debate on the maximum number of characters per line is bound to disappear. Not all letters take up the same amount of space. An ‘l’ or an ‘i’ clearly takes up less space than an ‘m’ or an ‘o’. However, when working with characters, each has its own space. Many subtitling programs work now with pixels in an attempt to rationalize the space available for the subtitles, since they allow the space to be adjusted according to the size of the letters.

Line breaks and conventions may also vary depending on the media. For instance, cinema subtitling tends to use shorter lines and centre them, despite the fact that the lines can actually be longer than on television. It also tends not to condense the original dialogue as much as television and to show great respect for shot changes and cuts in the spotting. The result is that the same film subtitled for the cinema usually has more subtitles than when subtitled for television. DVD is similar to cinema, but shows less respect for cut changes and prefers to use longer lines that can be easily read on a relatively small screen compared to the cinema one. The result is fewer subtitles than for the cinema, though not more condensation of information.

The typical commercial release of a feature film starts in the cinema, is followed by the copy on video – now defunct and superseded by the DVD – and finishes on television. Three or four subtitled versions of the same movie can be found on the market. Sometimes, even more when the film is broadcast by more than one TV station or sold on various DVDs, in the same or a different region (e.g. in Spanish for zone 1 for Latin America, and for zone 2 for Spain).

The process usually involves a gradual reduction in the number of subtitles; a change in the type of letter; a slight modification of both the structure

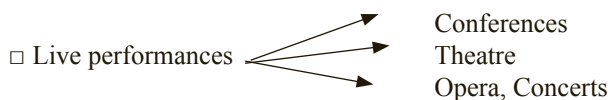
and the spotting of the subtitles, since the cinema illusion is based on a succession of 24 frames per second, whereas the small screen uses 25 frames per second in Europe and 30 in North America. To adjust the film print from cinema to television, the pace of the movie must be slightly sped up, reducing the length of the movie and the time available for subtitles by 4%. Generally speaking, a movie lasting approximately 90 minutes contains some 900 subtitles in the cinema, 750 on video or DVD, and 650 in the television version. However, to reduce costs the same subtitles are sometimes used regardless of the broadcast medium, which can force a higher reading speed, cause loss of definition, and make subtitles more difficult to read.

1.4 Surtitles

Also known as *supertitles* in the USA and *supratitles* by some scholars (Gambier 1994:276) they are a close relative to subtitles. They were developed by the Canadian Opera Company in Toronto, and the first production in the world to be presented with surtitles was the staging of *Elektra* in January 1983. They are the translation of the words being sung, if the opera is sung in another language, and can be considered the equivalent of subtitles in the cinema. Although they started in the opera, they have been gaining visibility since the 1980s and spreading to other areas like theatre and live performances in general. They have also developed to become more accessible, encompassing intralingual surtitling.

Surtitles tend to follow most of the conventions applied in subtitling and are shown on a LED display, normally placed above the stage. In fact, they are also called subtitles by many in the profession. They either scroll from right to left or are presented stationary in subtitles of two or three lines, which seems to be less distracting for the audience. Of late, many opera houses and theatres have also installed several smaller monitors throughout the theatre that are placed at the back of each seat in the auditorium. They are known as seat-back title screens and allow for subtitles to be provided in more than one language.

Given that we are dealing with live performances, spotting is usually one of the trickiest issues. It is normally done live by a technician so that the subtitles can follow the delivery of the original as closely as possible. Here is a list of events where surtitles can be used:



1.5 Intertitles

Intertitles are at the origin of subtitles and can be considered their oldest relatives, the first experiments with intertitles having taken place in the early 20th century. They are also known as ‘title cards’ and can be defined as a piece of filmed, printed text that appears between scenes. They were a mainstay of silent films and consisted of short sentences written against a dark background, usually white on black. Their main functions were to convey character dialogue and descriptive narrative material related to the images. Although communicative in essence, some directors also used them as an artistic and expressive device. The arrival of the soundtrack largely eliminated their usefulness, and when they are used in contemporary films they tend to be called inserts.

Very little has been written about their translation (Weinberg 1985), and very little research has been carried out, apart from the work done by Izard (1992) and Díaz Cintas (2001a:53-59). In the old times, the original intertitles used to be edited out and replaced by new title cards in the target language. On other occasions, the original intertitles were left and a sort of master of ceremonies translated and explained them to the rest of the audience. When translated for today’s viewers, they tend to be subtitled or voiced-over.

1.6 Fansubs

The extensive technological developments that have taken place in recent decades have had highly significant consequences for the world of AVT, media accessibility in general and subtitling in particular. The Internet has fully come of age. Computer subtitling programs have become much more affordable and accessible, with many of them available free on the net (see Appendix 2). These programs, known by those with an interest in the subject as subbing programs, have facilitated the rise and consolidation of translation practices like fansubs.

The origins of fansubbing go back to the 1980s, when it emerged as an attempt to popularize the Japanese cartoons known as *manga* and *anime*. American and European fans wanted to watch their favourite programmes but were faced with two main problems: on the one hand, the linguistic barrier and on the other, the scant distribution of these series in their respective countries. The alternative option was to subtitle these programmes themselves. Despite the questionable legality of this activity as far as the copyright of programmes is concerned, the philosophy underlying this type of subtitling is the free distribution over the Internet of audiovisual programmes with subtitles done by fans. The translations are done for free by aficionados of these

programmes and then posted on the Internet so that anyone who is interested may watch them.

This new form of subtitling ‘by fans for fans’ lies at the margins of market imperatives and is far less dogmatic and more creative and individualistic than what has traditionally been done. Some of its defining features are the use of colours to identify speakers, the incorporation of explicative glosses and metalinguistic notes in the subtitles themselves or on the top of the screen, and the use of cumulative subtitles (Díaz Cintas, forthcoming). In fact, some aficionados prefer to use the term *subbing*, instead of subtitling, in order to emphasize the peculiar nature of the activity.

In the first instance, this practice dealt solely with the subtitling of Japanese *anime* into English, but nowadays it has spread to other language combinations and other audiovisual programmes such as films. From an academic point of view, little research has been done to date in this field (Ferrer 2005; Díaz Cintas and Muñoz-Sánchez 2006; Bogucki, forthcoming), but it would be very interesting to research and analyze this new activity in detail, and to see whether or not some points of contact and parallelisms can be established between this new form of Internet subtitling and the more traditional types that we have been consuming in formats such as television, cinema or DVD.

1.7 Discussion points

- 1.7.1 Below is a quotation from Pommier (1988:22). What do you think about it?

It has to be understood that the subtitled text is not a proper translation, but rather a *simple adaptation* that preserves the general meaning of the original (our translation and our emphasis).

- 1.7.2 In your opinion, how does the fact that some scholars and professionals think of subtitling as a case of adaptation rather than proper translation affect the general perception of subtitling itself? Can you identify any other translating practices that could be considered to be in this intermediate position? Which?
- 1.7.3 Watch a movie or programme with subtitles in your mother tongue and draw up a list of at least five different features that define the subtitles you have seen on screen.
- 1.7.4 Watch a movie or programme that has closed captions in the same language for the deaf and the hard-of-hearing audiences and make a list of at least five different features that define the captions you saw on screen.

You can normally access closed captions on the teletext of your television set or on some DVDs.

- 1.7.5 What are the main differences that you have noticed in the two approaches? What is your personal opinion about the way the two types of subtitles are done?
- 1.7.6 Are there any techniques, aspects or strategies that interlingual subtitling could adapt from intralingual subtitling or vice versa to improve the presentation or quality of subtitles?
- 1.7.7 In your opinion, what is the social value of interlingual subtitles? And what would be the benefits of intralingual subtitles or closed captions?
- 1.7.8 If you want to experience fansubs there are many websites on Internet. You can go to either Animesuki (www.animesuki.com) or Animecubed (www.animecubed.com/anime-videos) for fansubs in English and to Frozen-Layer Network (<http://bittorrent.frozen-layer.net>) for fansubs in Spanish. In order to download one of the animes from any of these websites you need to have installed in your computer a program called Bittorrent (www.bittorrent.com). Be warned that the whole process of downloading the anime can take some three hours when using broadband.

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10.2 Filmography

- A Touch of Frost* (1992-2004), Roger Bamford, Roy Battersby *et al.*, UK.
Abba Live in Concert (1979).
About a Boy (2002), Chris Weitz and Paul Weitz, USA.
Aislados (2005), David Marqués, Spain.
American Beauty (1999), Sam Mendez, USA.
Amores perros / Love's a Bitch (2000), Alejandro González Iñárritu, Mexico.
Art in the Struggle for Freedom (2000), Obe Osheroff, USA.
Átame / Tie Me Up! Tie Me Down! (1990), Pedro Almodóvar, Spain.
¡Ay, Carmela! (1990), Carlos Saura, Spain/Italy.
Baby Cart in the Land of Demons / Kozure Ôkami: Meifumando (1973), Kenji Misumi, Japan.
Bang! Bang! In Da Manor (2004), Sean Mendez and Negar Esfandiari, UK.
Bataille d'Algers, La (1965), Gillo Pontecorvo, Italy.
Beneath the 12 Mile Reef (1953), Robert D. Webb, USA.
Big Lebowski, The (1998), Joel Coen, USA.
Blue Star Camp (2000), Adrian Smith, UK.
Blue Velvet (1986), David Lynch, USA.
Bookmark (1993), Randall Wright, UK.
Boom Boom Bang (1998), Hanno Baethe and Zaki Omar, Germany.
Bowling for Columbine (2002), Michael Moore, USA.
Brokeback Mountain (2005), Ang Lee, USA.
Broken Hearts Club, The (2000), Greg Berlanti, USA.
Cabaret (1972), Bob Fosse, USA.
Cachorro / Bear Cub (2004), Miguel Albaladejo, Spain.
Cage aux folles, La / Birds of a Feather (1978), Edouard Molinaro, France.
Cardiac Arrest (1994-1996), David Garnett and David Hayman, UK.
Casablanca (1942), Michael Curtiz, USA.
Charade (1963), Stanley Donen, USA.
Chicken Run (2000), Peter Lord and Nick Park, UK.
Cidade de Deus / City of God (2002), Fernando Meirelles and Kátia Lund, Brazil/France/USA.
Cielo abierto, El / Ten Days Without Love (2001), Miguel Albaladejo, Spain.
Cold Feet (1998-2003), Nigel Cole, Ciaran Donnelly *et al.*, UK.
Color Purple, The (1985), Steven Spielberg, USA.
Commitments, The (1991), Alan Parker, Ireland/UK/USA.
Crying Game, The (1992), Neil Jordan, UK/Japan.
Cyrano de Bergerac (1900) Jean-Paul Rappeneau, France.
Depuis qu'Otar est parti... / Since Otar Left (2003), Julie Bertucelli, Belgium/France.
Elling (2001), Petter Næss, Norway.
ER (1994-present), Michael Crichton *et al.*, USA.
Erin Brockovich (2000), Steven Soderbergh, USA.

- European Picture Book Collection* (2003), Penni Cotton, UK.
- Father's Little Dividend* (1950), Vincente Minnelli, USA.
- Faulty Towers* (1975-1979), John Howard Davies and Bob Spiers, UK.
- Flikken* (1999-present), Pierre De Clerq *et al.*, Belgium.
- Flor de mi secreto, La / Flower of my Secret, The* (1995), Pedro Amodóvar, Spain/France.
- Fond Kiss... Ae* (2004), Ken Loach, UK/Belgium/Germany/Italy/Spain.
- Four Weddings and a Funeral* (1994), Mike Newell, UK.
- Frasier* (1993-2004), David Angell *et al.*, USA.
- French Lieutenant's Woman, The* (1981), Karel Reisz, UK.
- Friends* (1994-2004), David Crane, Martha Kauffman *et al.*, USA.
- From Dusk till Dawn* (1996), Robert Rodriguez, USA.
- Full Monty, The* (1997), Peter Cattaneo, UK.
- Gazon Maudit / French Twist* (1995), Josiane Balasko, France.
- Gone with the Wind* (1939), Victor Fleming, USA.
- Grapes of Wrath, The* (1940), John Ford, USA.
- Guantanamo* (1995), Tomás Gutiérrez Alea and Juan Carlos Tabío, Cuba/Spain/Germany.
- Haine, La* (1995), Matthieu Kassovitz, France.
- Hard Talk* (1997-present), BBC-TV interview series, UK.
- Have Your Cake and Eat It* (1997), Paul Seed, UK.
- Head on* (1998), Ana Kokkinos, Australia.
- Historia oficial, La / Official Story, The* (1985), Luis Puenzo, Argentina.
- Hola, estás sola? / Hi, Are You Alone* (1995), Icíar Bollain, Spain.
- Holcroft Covenant, The* (1985), John Frankenheimer, UK.
- Hollow Man* (2000), Paul Verhoeven, USA.
- Hours, The* (2002), Stephen Daldry, USA.
- J'ai toujours voulu être une sainte / I Always Wanted To Be a Saint* (2003), Geneviève Mersch, Belgium/Luxembourg.
- Jamón, jamón / A Tale of Ham and Passion* (1992), José Juan Bigas Luna, Spain.
- Joseph and the Amazing Technicolor Dreamcoat* (1999), David Mallet and Steven Pimlott, UK.
- Last Time I Saw Paris, The* (1954), Richard Brooks, USA.
- Liaison Pornographique, Une* (1999), Frédéric Fonteyne, France/Switzerland/Belgium/Luxembourg.
- Life of Brian, The* (1979), Terry Jones, UK.
- Lijmen* (2000), Robbe De Hert, Belgium.
- Loaded* (1994), Anna Campion, New Zealand/UK.
- Lois & Clark: The New Adventures of Superman* (1993-1997), Joe Shuster, USA.
- Look Who's Talking* (1989), Amy Heckerling, USA.
- Lost in Translation* (2003), Sofia Coppola, USA.
- Mamaman* (2002), Iao Lethem, Belgium.
- Man with the Golden Arm, The* (1955), Otto Preminger, USA.

- Manhattan Murder Mystery* (1993), Woody Allen, USA.
Mar adentro / Sea Inside, The (2004), Alejandro Amenábar, Spain/France/Italy.
Max et Bobo (1998), Frédéric Fonteyne, Belgium/Luxembourg/France.
McLintock! (1963), Andrew V. McLaglen, USA.
Memento (2000), Christopher Nolan, USA.
Men in Black (1997), Barry Sonnenfeld, USA.
Mobutu, Roi du Zaïre / Mobutu, King of Zaïre (1999), Thierry Michel, Belgium/France.
Moulin Rouge (2001), Baz Luhrmann, Australia.
Mr Bean (1990-1995), John Birkin, John Howard Davies et al., UK.
Mrs Doubtfire (1993), Chris Columbus, USA.
Mujeres al borde de un ataque de nervios / Women on the Verge of a Nervous Breakdown (1988), Pedro Almodóvar, Spain.
My Big Fat Greek Wedding (2002), Joel Zwick, USA/Canada.
My Fair Lady (1964), George Cukor, USA.
My Name is Joe (1998), Ken Loach, Spain/Italy/France/UK/Germany.
Night of the Living Dead, The (1968), George A. Romero, USA.
Nueve reinas / Nine Queens (2000), Fabián Bielinsky, Argentina.
Pourquoi se marier le jour de la fin du monde ? / Why Get Married the Day the World Ends? (2000), Harry Cleven, Belgium/Luxembourg.
Prime Suspect (1991-2003), Christopher Menaul et al., UK.
Princess Mononoke / Mononoke-hime (1997), Hayao Miyazaki, Japan.
Pulp Fiction (1994), Quentin Tarantino, USA.
¿Qué he hecho yo para merecer esto? / What Have I Done to Deserve This? (1984), Pedro Almodóvar, Spain.
Rich and Famous (1981), George Cukor, USA.
Rocky Horror Picture Show, The (1975), Jim Sharman, UK.
Romeo and Juliet (1968), Franco Zeffirelli, UK/Italy.
Russia House, The (1990), Fred Schepisi, USA.
Secrets and Lies (1996), Mike Leigh, France/UK.
Seinfeld (1990-1998), Larry David, Jerry Seinfeld et al., USA.
Shakespeare in Love (1998), John Madden, USA/UK.
Shrek (2001), Andrew Adamson and Vicky Jenson, USA.
Sicilia, La (1997), Luc Pien, Belgium.
Simpsons, The (1989-present), Matt Groening et al., USA.
Snows of Kilimanjaro, The (1952), Henry King, USA.
Sound of Music, The (1965), Robert Wise, USA.
Star Wars (1977), George Lucas, USA.
Stargate (1994), Roland Emmerich, USA.
Stranger, The (1946), Orson Welles, USA.
Stuart Little (1999), Rob Minkoff, USA.
Sweet Sixteen (2002), Ken Loach, UK/Germany/Spain.
Taxi Driver (1976), Martin Scorsese, USA.
Thelma & Louise (1991), Ridley Scott, USA.
Trainspotting (1996), Danny Boyle, UK.

Voices from Robben Island (1995), Adam Low, UK.

Zatoichi's Pilgrimage / Zatôichi umi o wataru (1966), Kazuo Ikehiro, Japan.